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Chapter 2

Chapter 2 Literature Review

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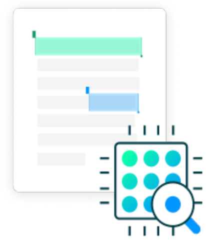

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LITERATURE REVIEW

Introduction

This chapter investigates the current literature and technological underpinnings pertinent to the creation of the Al-Muneer Online Portal. It examines the field of online event venue management systems, highlighting the transition from conventional manual operations to digital platforms that provide improved functionality. The discourse encompasses essential features anticipated in contemporary venue portals, such as systems for managing inquiries, straightforward booking confirmation processes (including the submission of payment proof), collection of feedback, basic reporting dashboards, and client notification systems. Additionally, this chapter introduces a case study of Al-Muneer Hall to contextualize the system's development. It evaluates the shortcomings of existing manual processes and contrasts the proposed system with current solutions or alternative methods. Moreover, this chapter surveys the literature related to the specific technologies chosen for the portal's development, substantiating their appropriateness for the implementation of these comprehensive features (O'Brien & Marakas, 2011).

Project Domain

The Al-Muneer Online Portal is categorized as a specialized web-based platform that provides information, manages inquiries, and supports operations within the event management and hospitality sectors. These systems are designed to close the communication divide between venue providers and prospective clients, delivering greater efficiency, accessibility, enhanced transactional features, and superior post-interaction engagement when contrasted with conventional approaches (Sigala et al., 2012; Buhalis & Law, 2008).

2.2.1 Key Features and Information Architecture for Event Venue Portals

Modern event venue websites have evolved beyond simple static brochures to become interactive platforms. Literature highlights several critical components for success:

Visual Appeal and Information Richness: High-quality imagery and detailed descriptions remain crucial (Ukpabi & Karjaluoto, 2017).

Availability Information: Interactive calendars are a core expectation for instant information (Werthner & Ricci, 2004).

Pricing Transparency: Clear pricing, even if base rates, is valued (Hayes & Miller, 2011).

Clear Call-to-Actions and Inquiry Forms: Essential for lead generation (Nielsen, 2000).

Simple Booking Confirmation/Payment Proof: In contexts where full online payment gateways are not feasible or common, providing a mechanism for users to submit proof of offline payment (e.g., bank transfer receipt, payment app screenshot) is a practical alternative to streamline booking confirmation. This reflects an adaptation to local payment ecosystems (Kshetri, 2013, on mobile payments in developing economies).

Feedback Mechanisms: Incorporating systems for users to provide feedback on the venue or service is vital for continuous improvement and demonstrating customer centricity. Online feedback forms are a common implementation (Morgan et al., 2003).

Client Notification Systems: Automated or semi-automated notifications (e.g., for inquiry received, booking confirmed, payment acknowledged) enhance customer communication and reduce uncertainty. The choice of channel (email, SMS, WhatsApp) should align with user preferences and local infrastructure (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010, on social media and mobile communication).

Basic Reporting for Administrators: For venue owners, access to simple reports on inquiries, booking statuses, and feedback trends provides valuable insights for operational management and decision-making without requiring complex business intelligence tools (Davenport & Harris, 2007).

Accessibility and Usability: The portal must be easily navigable, responsive, and culturally appropriate (W3C, 2018; Marcus & Gould, 2000).

The information architecture should logically integrate these functionalities, ensuring a seamless user journey from initial exploration to inquiry, potential payment proof submission, and feedback.

2.2.2 Manual Operation Analysis

The current manual system at Al-Muneer Hall is common among SMEs but suffers from inefficiencies:

Time Consumption: Staff spend time on repetitive queries and manual tracking of bookings, payments, and feedback. (Laudon & Laudon, 2016).

Limited Availability: Information and process progression are tied to staff hours.

Inconsistency: Information can vary; tracking booking confirmations and feedback lacks standardization.

Lack of Scalability: Handling increased volume becomes difficult.

Poor User Experience: Customers expect streamlined online interactions, including clear confirmation steps and ways to voice opinions (Sigala et al., 2012).

Documentation and Oversight Challenges: Manual tracking makes it hard to generate operational insights or reliably follow up on client interactions.

The shift to a specialized portal resolves these issues by automating data management, standardizing the procedures for booking confirmations and feedback, ensuring round-the-clock accessibility, and delivering fundamental reporting for enhanced oversight (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019).

2.2.3 Current System Analysis - Comparison of Existing Systems/Approaches

Before making a direct comparison, it is essential to outline the categories of existing systems or methodologies that establishments like Al-Muneer Hall may currently utilize or contemplate. The existing manual process, as practiced at Al-Muneer Hall and common among many small to medium-sized enterprises (SMEs), relies significantly on direct human interaction for all customer engagement and booking management.

Communication primarily takes place through phone calls, in-person meetings, and informal messaging platforms such as WhatsApp. Although this method provides a high degree of personalization, it is labor-intensive, has limited scalability, and poses risks of inconsistencies in information dissemination and record-keeping (Harrigan et al., 2012). Bookings, payment confirmations, and feedback are generally managed in an unstructured manner, lacking a cohesive or centralized system.

Another category encompasses generic online booking platforms, such as Eventbrite or Cvent. These third-party services offer a wide range of features for event listing, ticketing, and occasionally comprehensive event management. They typically provide a standardized interface for users to discover and reserve events or services. Despite their capabilities, they may impose their own branding, fee structures, and workflows that may not correspond with the specific needs or cultural context of an independent venue (Gazzaroli et al., 2019). Their primary emphasis is often on ticketed events, which contrasts with tailored venue rental requests.

Moreover, user-friendly website builders such as Wix, Squarespace, and GoDaddy Website Builder allow individuals and small enterprises to construct websites with relative simplicity by utilizing pre-designed templates and drag-and-drop functionalities (Odoom et al., 2017). These platforms serve as excellent tools for establishing a fundamental online presence and showcasing information. Nevertheless, their built-in capabilities for dynamic processes, including custom availability calendars, tailored pricing for intricate services, integrated payment proof workflows, or backend reporting, are frequently restricted unless enhanced by third-party plugins, which may add further complexity or expenses.

In addition, within numerous local business contexts, it is typical to find standard static competitor websites. These sites predominantly operate as online brochures, offering contact details, a gallery, and possibly a list of services. They usually lack interactive elements for checking availability, acquiring dynamic pricing, submitting structured inquiries, or managing other transactional functions online. Their main purpose is informational, still requiring users to reach out via phone or email for most significant interactions.

A comparative analysis helps to position the proposed Al-Muneer Online Portal:

Feature

Al-Muneer Online Portal (Proposed)

Manual (Phone/WhatsApp)

Generic Booking Platforms [Gazzaroli et al., 2019]

Simple Website Builders [Odoom et al., 2017]

Static Competitor Website

Venue-Specific Info

Tailored

(Manual)

Generic Structure

(Manual Setup)

Basic

Interactive Calendar

Yes

No

Often (Complex Setup)

Limited/Plugin Dependent

Often No

Dynamic Pricing Display

Yes (Admin Managed)

(Verbal/Manual)

Sometimes (Complex)

Usually No

Often No

Admin Panel

Custom Built

N/A

Yes (Platform Specific)

(General CMS)

N/A

Payment Proof Upload

Yes (Simple)

(Manual Exchange)

Often Not Direct

No

No

Feedback System

Yes

(Ad-hoc)

Sometimes (Platform)

Usually No

No

Basic Reporting

Yes

No

Limited (Platform)

No

No

Notifications (SMS/WA)

Yes (Focused)

(Manual)

Email Often Primary

No

No

Cultural Context Adapt

High (Custom Design)

High (Direct Interaction)

Low (Standardized)

Medium (Template Dependent)

Medium

Table 2.1: Comparative Analysis of Existing Systems and the Proposed Portal

Analysis of Existing Systems/Approaches:

The manual process is characterized by significant inefficiencies and is devoid of structured mechanisms for confirmation, feedback, or oversight. While generic booking platforms may present some advanced features, they frequently fall short in providing the tailored simplicity that is essential, particularly regarding payment processes in specific economic contexts. Additionally, these platforms may not cater to local communication preferences, such as WhatsApp or SMS for notifications (Buhalis & Law, 2008). Furthermore, simple website builders typically do not incorporate integrated backend functionalities necessary for managing payment proofs, systematically collecting feedback, or generating specific operational reports. In response to these challenges, the proposed Al-Muneer Online Portal aims to deliver a comprehensive, customized solution that effectively addresses the unique operational flow of the venue, encompassing everything from initial inquiry to straightforward booking confirmation and feedback. This entire process is managed through a bespoke admin panel that provides relevant insights and communication tools tailored to the local environment (Laudon & Laudon, 2016).

2.2.4 Case Study: Al-Muneer Hall for Weddings and Events

In order to anchor the project within a practical framework, this section provides an overview of Al-Muneer Hall, the establishment for which the proposed system is being designed. Al-Muneer Hall ("قاعة المنير للأفراح والمناسبات") serves as an event venue situated in Ibb, Yemen. Its main function is to host weddings, thereby serving the local community and preserving the traditional Yemeni cultural customs linked to such celebrations. Additionally, the hall is equipped to host various social events, including condolence gatherings and special celebrations, thus providing a flexible venue for a range of activities. The business operates from a singular physical site. Regarding its organizational structure, Al-Muneer Hall is classified as an owner-operated enterprise. The principal stakeholder is Mr. Ahmed Almunajid, who plays an active role in the daily operations and client relations. Although there may be additional personnel for event preparation, cleaning, and assistance during events, the essential tasks related to administration, booking, and client communication are primarily managed or directly supervised by Mr. Almunajid or his manager. This centralized approach to management highlights the necessity for tools that can improve efficiency and alleviate the owner's direct involvement in operational tasks.

The primary method of engagement for this project involved direct interaction with the owner, Mr. Ahmed Almunajid. Initial discussions were conducted via a scheduled video conference (Google Meet) on April 4, 2025, to understand the business, its current processes, challenges, and his vision for an online portal. This was followed by ongoing asynchronous communication via WhatsApp for clarifications and to gather specific details, as evidenced by communication logs and the NABC proposal document. Key findings from this engagement, effectively forming the basis of a user interview and requirements gathering phase, revealed a significant portion of Mr. Almunajid's time is spent answering repetitive phone calls regarding availability, pricing, venue capacity, and visual details. There was a clear desire for a professional online presence to accurately showcase the hall. Specific feature requests included an interactive calendar, a clear way to display pricing, a media gallery, and an FAQ section. The current booking process involves phone or in-person arrangements, with payment typically in cash, although local bank transfers with screenshot proof are emerging. There is no formal system for tracking these proofs or managing feedback. Communication preferences lean heavily towards WhatsApp and direct calls over email, reflecting local business practices. A core need identified was for a system that is easy for Mr. Almunajid to manage and for his clients to use. Following discussions about the initial proposal feedback, Mr. Almunajid expressed openness to incorporating a simple mechanism for clients to upload payment proof, a feature for clients to submit feedback, basic reports on inquiries and booking statuses, and automated notifications, preferably via SMS or WhatsApp. These interactions confirmed the problem statement and helped refine the scope and objectives of the Al-Muneer Online Portal project, ensuring its alignment with the stakeholder's genuine needs.

Literature Review of Technology Used

The selection of technologies for the Al-Muneer Online Portal is based on their suitability for developing a robust, scalable, and maintainable web application that meets the defined requirements, including the newly added functionalities. For each core technology, alternatives were considered.

Technology

Purpose

Alternatives Considered

Why Chosen / Developer Justification

Spring Boot (Java) / MVC

Backend framework

Python (Django/Flask), Node.js (Express.js), PHP (Laravel)

I’m already experienced in Spring MVC but that is not the main reason, Spring boot gives you everything you need from authentication to the design pattern infrastructure so you only focus on implementing the idea because the heavy lefting has been done for us in a complete nicely wrapped backend framework.

MySQL / PostgreSQL

Relational database

NoSQL (MongoDB, Cassandra), SQLite, MS SQL Server

There is no need for NoSQL database for this project because e’re not dealing with unstructed type of data. Postgress sounds a good solid choice. Everyone loves it. It does the job perfectly and it’s open source.

HTML5, CSS3, JS (Responsive)

Frontend development

JavaScript Frameworks (React, Angular, Vue.js)

“An idiot admires complexity, a genius admires simplicity” — Terry Davis, Creator of Temple OS

Waterfall Model

SDLC methodology

Agile (Scrum, Kanban), Spiral Model

Sounds solid when having clear requirements of a moderate software that does not seem to be needing frequent and high-maintenance in post development

Cloud Hosting (VPS)

Deployment environment

AWS, serverless

VPS is the safest option against DDoS attacks that could cause massive cloud computing bills

Admin Auth (Hashed Pass.)

Secure admin login

Plain text storage (highly insecure), Reversible encryption

The encryption standard in web development

Notification Mechanisms

(e.g., SMS Gateway API, Email libraries, Manual WhatsApp)

In-app notifications (not a native app), Full WhatsApp Business API integration

notifications sound simple to implement though it’s very effective compared to the other complex means that the stakeholder does not really need given the complexity and return on that.

Table 2.2: Technology Stack Selection and Justification

The Model-View-Controller (MVC) architecture, enabled by Spring Boot, guarantees a clear separation of concerns, thereby simplifying the management and scalability of the application (Fowler, 2002). Relational database systems such as MySQL or PostgreSQL ensure data integrity, which is essential for the effective management of bookings and venue details (Garcia-Molina et al., 2008). Implementing responsive design through HTML5, CSS3, and JavaScript is imperative for contemporary web applications to accommodate a variety of user devices (W3C, 2018). Although Agile methodologies are widely embraced, the structured approach of the Waterfall model can be beneficial for projects with well-defined initial requirements, as described in the proposal phase (Royce, 1970). Ensuring security through HTTPS and appropriate password hashing is critical for maintaining user trust and safeguarding data (Rescorla, 2001; Schneier, 1996). Cloud hosting provides both flexibility and reliability for application deployment (Armbrust et al., 2010).

Chapter Summary

This chapter provided an extensive examination of the literature pertinent to the Al-Muneer Online Portal. It defined the scope of the project within the realm of online event venue management systems, emphasizing key features recognized in prior research, including rich visual displays, interactive availability calendars, clear pricing information, user feedback mechanisms, straightforward booking confirmation processes, basic reporting, and client notification systems. The shortcomings of conventional manual operations, as illustrated by the current practices at Al-Muneer Hall, were scrutinized, highlighting the urgent need for a digital transformation. A case study focusing on Al-Muneer Hall offered specific context, outlining stakeholder engagement and the resulting business requirements. Various existing system categories, such as generic booking platforms and basic website builders, were described and contrasted with the proposed custom portal, thereby validating the tailored approach. In conclusion, the chapter assessed the selected technology stack, exploring alternatives and justifying the choice of Spring Boot, a relational database, standard frontend technologies, and the Waterfall methodology, with references to established principles and industry best practices.